

Learn Copywriting: Beginner's Mastery

Lesson 7: Editing & Proofreading Basics

Editing & Proofreading Basics – Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Clarity:** Make every sentence easy to understand; eliminate ambiguity and jargon.
2. **Brevity:** Convey the same message with fewer words; cut filler, redundancies, and wordy phrases.
3. **Grammar & Mechanics:** Apply standard rules for punctuation, verb tense, subject verb agreement, and consistent style.
4. **Proofreading Checklist:** A step by step list to catch common errors before finalizing copy.
5. **Editing for Impact:** Adjust tone, active voice, and word choice to strengthen the persuasive power of an ad.

Summary

Effective editing and proofreading are the twin pillars of polished, professional writing. The **clarity** component ensures the reader instantly grasps the intended meaning, while **brevity** respects the reader's time and often boosts the persuasiveness of copy—especially in advertising where space is limited. Grammar and mechanics provide the structural backbone; even a brilliant idea can be dismissed if it's riddled with errors or inconsistent formatting.

A practical way to internalize these principles is to work through a checklist that addresses the major error categories (spelling, punctuation, tense consistency, subject verb agreement, parallelism, and word choice). After a macro edit for clarity and brevity, a focused proofread catches the remaining surface level slips. The lesson's hands on activity—trimming a sample advertisement by 10 %—demonstrates how small cuts and word swaps can preserve the core message while making the copy tighter and more compelling.

Important Points

- **Clarity Checklist**
 - Is each sentence about one main idea?
 - Are pronouns clearly linked to their antecedents?
 - Have jargon or vague terms been replaced with concrete language?
- **Brevity Techniques**
 - Remove filler words (e.g., "very," "actually," "just").
 - Replace phrases with single words (e.g., "in order to" ! "to").
 - Cut redundant information ("each and every," "free gift" ! "gift").
- **Grammar & Mechanics**
 - Consistent tense throughout a piece.

- Subject verb agreement, especially with collective nouns and intervening clauses.
- Proper punctuation for readability (commas after introductory clauses, Oxford comma for lists if your style guide requires it).

- **Proofreading Checklist (run through twice)**

1. **Spelling & Typos** – run a spell check, then scan manually for homophones (their/there/they're).
2. **Punctuation** – verify commas, periods, quotation marks, and hyphens.
3. **Numbers & Symbols** – spell out numbers under ten, ensure consistent use of % vs. “percent.”
4. **Formatting** – uniform font, headings, bullet style, and line spacing.
5. **Consistency** – brand voice, terminology, and style (APA, Chicago, AP, etc.).

- **Editing a Sample Ad (10 % reduction)**

1. Identify wordy phrases and cut them.
2. Combine short, related sentences using commas or conjunctions.
3. Replace weak verbs with stronger, more direct ones.
4. Verify that the core selling point remains intact.

Examples

Example 1 – Original Ad (112 words)

> “Are you looking for a reliable, high quality, and affordable cleaning service that will leave your home sparkling clean? Our team of professional cleaners uses only the best, eco friendly products, and we guarantee that you will be completely satisfied with the results. Call us today and schedule a free, no obligation consultation, and we’ll give you a special discount on your first cleaning appointment!”

Edited (10 % shorter !’ 101 words)

> “Need a reliable, affordable cleaning service that leaves your home sparkling? Our professional team uses eco friendly products and guarantees your satisfaction. Call today for a free, no obligation consultation and receive a special discount on your first cleaning.”

What changed?

- Removed redundant adjectives (“high quality,” “completely”).
- Combined two sentences into one concise question.
- Replaced “we’ll give you” with “receive.”
- Cut filler phrases (“schedule a,” “the results”).

Example 2 – Proofreading Spot Check

> **Original:** “The company’s new product line, which includes three different models, are designed for both beginners and experienced users alike.”

Corrected: “The company’s new product line, which includes three different models, **is** designed for both beginners and experienced users alike.”

Why? – The subject “product line” is singular; the verb must be “is,” not “are.”

Quick Review

1. **What are the three pillars of effective editing?**
2. **Name two common filler words that can usually be removed without changing meaning.**
3. **When editing for brevity, why is it important to keep the core message intact?**

4. **Identify the error in this sentence: “Each of the employees have completed their training.”**
5. **Give one practical step you would take to reduce an advertisement’s length by 10 %.**

Further Reading

- **Style Guides:** AP Stylebook, Chicago Manual of Style, The Elements of Style (Strunk & White)
- **Copywriting Fundamentals:** “The Copywriter’s Handbook” by Robert W. Bly
- **Advanced Proofreading Techniques:** “Proofreading Secrets of Best Selling Authors” by Kathy Ide
- **Editing for Digital Media:** SEO friendly copy, readability scores (Flesch Kincaid), and mobile first considerations
- **Tools & Resources:** Grammarly, Hemingway App, ProWritingAid, and built in word processor track changes features

Use these notes as a quick reference while you practice editing real copy. The more you apply the checklist, the more instinctive clear, concise, and error free writing becomes.

